

CAUTIOUS OPTIMISM FOR PARIS BUT **BLUEPRINT FOR BETTER FUTURE NEEDED**

When it comes to champion-building, the year 2024 should serve as a **great reality-check** on where the sport is headed in the country.

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Ironic as it sounds, the performance dynamics of Indian badminton have changed dramatically in the past decade, but the quantum of joy gained by the lovers of the sport in the country is more or less the same. From the days of meagre Indian presence in singles and almost making a token appearance in doubles, the sport has moved to the other end of the scale. In 2023, there was very little to look forward to in the women's singles, the source of excitement for home-grown fans since 2006. Men's singles provided just a few moments to cheer, thanks to the never-say-die spirit of H. S. Prannoy.

While the lone men's doubles pair of Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy shone the brightest, the mixed doubles continued to lack a cutting edge, and the women's

doubles remained a work in progress. As a result, the Indian badminton cupboard stood bare for everyone to see.

Before delving into the stagnant side of the game in India, let's rejoice in the moments that brought joy and pride to the badminton court. Chirag and Satwik's achievements, including becoming Asian champions, securing three titles from four Tour finals, and attaining the World No. 1 spot, were undeniably the highlights of the year.

Starting the year with a bronze in the Badminton Asia mixed team championship, the first success came at the Swiss Open. For the World Championship bronze medallists, the Asian title came in Dubai, and the duo changed gears to win its first BWF World Super 1000 title by claiming the Indonesian Open. The two went on to add the Korea Open title next. The only runner-up finish was in the China Masters, where they lost a close three-game encounter.

Lakshya Sen struggled with fitness

issues, and the nose surgery added to the delay in the youngster producing his best. Prannoy made the Indian presence noticeable and finished the year as World No. 8. The most impressive aspect of Prannoy was that he stayed in the world top-10 after starting the year at 8.

On the Tour, consistency helped Prannoy defend the points earned in 2022. He won the Malaysia Masters and finished runner-up in the Australian Open. Semifinal appearances in the Indonesia Open, World Championship, and Asian Games— both worth a bronze medal — lent some more sheen to his report card. Being the quarterfinalists of the Malaysia Open, Asian Championship, Taipei Open, Japan Open, and China Open were the other reasonably good finishes.

For the record, 16th-ranked Lakshya triumphed in the not-so-strong Canadian Open. He reached the semifinals of the Thailand Open, US Open, and Japan